DURBAN & DISTRICTS SCHOOL CHESS

Community Update — August 2026

Dear Principals, Teachers, Coaches and School Chess Coordinators,

It has been five months since the current Durban & Districts School Chess Committee took office, and we are pleased to share our first Community Update with you.

Over the past few months, our focus has been on strengthening the foundations of D&D and investing in the future of school chess. While much of this work has taken place behind the scenes, we believe it is important to keep our member schools informed of the progress being made.

While there is still much to accomplish, we are pleased to share some of the progress made so far.

✨ FIVE MONTHS AT A GLANCE ✨

👩‍🏫 **22 Teachers completed the FIDE PoT Programme**	🏢 **Sponsorship Secured: R80,000**
♟️ **CHESSA-Rated Tournaments Introduced**	👨‍⚖️ **Qualified Arbiter Database in Development**
📱 **Facebook Page & WhatsApp Community Launched**	🎯 **Tournament Equipment Upgraded**
🏆 **D&D School League in Development**	✨ **Fresh new D&D logo introduced**
📋 **Governance documents and Codes of Conduct established**	🗂️ **Asset Register Established**

PoT = FIDE's Preparation of Teachers course, which trains educators to use chess as a tool to build critical thinking, creativity and other 21st-century skills in learners — not just to produce stronger chess players.

Strengthening Governance

One of our first priorities has been strengthening the governance and administrative structures of D&D.

When the new committee took office it found D&D had been without a formal Constitution. Over the past few months, the committee has been working to draft a Constitution and establish a governance framework that will provide the organisation with greater accountability, transparency and long-term sustainability.

Together with supporting policies and procedures, this work will provide a stronger foundation for D&D as we continue to grow and serve our member schools.

Investing in Teachers

One of the highlights of the past five months was hosting KwaZulu-Natal's first in-person **FIDE Preparation of Teachers (PoT) Course**.

This internationally recognised course equips educators with innovative methods to use chess as a tool for enhancing cognitive skills—such as critical thinking, problem-solving, and creativity—while simultaneously developing both chess proficiency and transferable classroom teaching abilities.

="Anzel is a magnet. I was glued to the presentations. Very stimulating."
— Reenoka Parbulall, Atholton Primary School

The success of the course would not have been possible without the support secured by D&D for teacher development. **A total of R80,000 in sponsorship and support was secured**, including accommodation and meals sponsored by Sugar Bay Holiday Resort to the value of R69,000, together with D&D's contribution towards course fees for affiliated schools.

22 Teachers completed the FIDE Preparation of Teachers Programme.

"Passion can't be faked. It was real. I felt valued, seen, respected & protected. She was very knowledgeable but very humble."
— Life Ngoma, Umhlali Preparatory School



Teachers at the FIDE Preparation of Teachers (PoT) Course

Raising Tournament Standards

One of the key changes introduced by the new committee has been the move towards **CHESSA-rated tournaments**.

Previously, D&D tournaments were not rated, meaning learners did not earn official national ratings through their participation. Our move to rated events gives learners the opportunity to build an official national rating, track their competitive progress and gain experience in a recognised competitive environment.

We have deliberately kept entry fees as low as possible — covering little more than the rating costs — because we believe access to rated chess should not be limited by cost. Our goal is to give more learners the opportunity to play competitive chess and create a clear pathway for development.

Building Our Pool of Qualified Arbiters

We have also begun building a **database of qualified arbiters**, with the aim of establishing a rotating panel and introducing a transparent process for the appointment and remuneration of arbiters at future D&D tournaments.

Increasing the number of qualified arbiters within our community is also part of our longer-term vision for D&D, helping us build the capacity required to run more structured and professional tournaments in the future.

Keeping Our Promises to the Chess Community

The 2026 calendar inherited by the new committee included events that the school chess community had been expecting to see take place. When the original hosting arrangements for the two main events fell away, the new committee made the decision to **step up rather than allow these opportunities to disappear from the calendar**.

Securing venues and putting these tournaments together at short notice has required considerable work behind the scenes. We are incredibly grateful to **Umhlali Preparatory School and Clifton School** for stepping forward and making it possible for us to host these events.

We have also made an important change to the way these tournaments are positioned. Rather than calling them **“Trials”**, we have renamed them **“Opens.”** The term *Trials* suggests that learners are competing for selection or progressing to another representative event. That is not the purpose of these tournaments.

The D&D Opens are about **giving learners the opportunity to play, compete and develop**. They are open to all D&D-affiliated schools, creating a broader and more inclusive competitive opportunity for our school chess community.

And we want to go further. **If numbers and tournament capacity allow, we intend to open participation to players from outside the D&D affiliation network who meet the relevant playing criteria.** Our priority is to create as many meaningful competitive opportunities for young chess players as possible while continuing to strengthen the D&D school chess network.

Our Major 2026 Opens — Don't Miss Out!

- D&D Junior Primary Open — Umhlali Preparatory School — 15 August 2026
- D&D Senior Primary Open — Clifton School — 12 September 2026

If your school hasn't yet signed up, drop us an email and we will send you all the details.



A Clarification on the D&D Calendar

You may have noticed a number of tournaments appearing on the D&D calendar, and we have found that this has created some confusion among schools. We felt it was important to clarify the position.

The calendar was **inherited from the previous committee**, and in the interest of maintaining continuity, the incoming committee agreed to retain the events that had already been listed. However, the inclusion of these events on the D&D calendar **does not mean that they are official D&D events**.

These are independently organised tournaments, and **D&D does not administer, manage or control these events**. Their inclusion on the calendar has unfortunately created some confusion, with schools understandably assuming that tournaments appearing there are D&D-organised or endorsed events.

It is equally important to make it clear that **D&D does not dictate whether, when or how a school may host a chess tournament**. Schools are encouraged to promote chess, create opportunities for their learners and develop a strong chess culture within their school communities. We welcome initiatives that give more children the opportunity to play and grow in the sport.

The distinction is simply one of **official D&D events versus independently organised events**. Schools remain free to organise and participate in chess activities outside of the official D&D programme.

From **2027, the official D&D calendar will be reserved for D&D activities only**, including official D&D League fixtures and tournaments organised or formally sanctioned by D&D. This will make it much easier for schools to identify which events form part of the official D&D programme, while still leaving the wider chess community free to create and host opportunities of its own.

Our aim is not to restrict chess — it is to grow it. The more opportunities our learners have to play, the stronger our school chess community becomes.

Investing in Equipment

We have begun upgrading D&D's tournament equipment, moving from paper chess boards to high-quality fabric boards and upgrading our chess sets. As resources allow, we hope to continue investing in equipment, including increasing the number of chess clocks available for future tournaments.

D&D 2025 → 2026: Building for the Future

In just five months, the 2026 D&D committee has focused on more than running tournaments. We have been building the **resources, systems, opportunities and infrastructure needed to strengthen school chess across the district.**

What Has Changed?

Area	2025	2026
Chess boards	89 paper boards	189 boards (100 vinyl)
Chess sets	86	106
Chess clocks	11 (1 not functional)	11 (1 not functional) — no new clocks purchased yet
Teachers trained	0	22
D&D sponsorships	R0	R80,000
Asset register	Not in place	Established

From Manual to Modern

School Database
2025 — No centralised database
2026 — Centralised D&D school database established

Tournament Registration
2025 — Manual registration
2026 — Online registration process introduced

Digital Communication
2025 — Limited digital presence
2026 — Active Facebook page and WhatsApp Community

Asset Register
2025 — No formal asset register
2026 — Asset register established

The Difference Is More Than Numbers

These figures represent more than equipment purchased or schools affiliated. They reflect a deliberate move towards **building a stronger, more organised and more sustainable school chess structure**.

From equipment and teacher development to technology, databases, sponsorships and competitive opportunities, the focus has been on putting the foundations in place for the next stage of D&D School Chess.

2026 is about building. 2027 is about taking that foundation forward.

Growing Our School Community

Our focus is not simply on increasing the number of affiliated schools, but on building a connected school chess community where schools have access to tournaments, teacher development, resources, communication and opportunities for their learners to progress.

High School League

The D&D High School League has been running successfully under the leadership of **Mrs Nagiah of DHS**, and we are pleased to see the league continuing to provide regular competitive opportunities for high school players.

For 2026, we are excited to introduce a **dedicated prize-giving ceremony**, including trophies and medals to recognise and celebrate the achievements of our high school players.

There will be **no High School Open tournament in 2026**. At our last AGM, high school representatives indicated that they were happy for the league to continue operating independently under the current system.

Strengthening Communication

To better support our schools, D&D has:

- Launched the official D&D Facebook page
- Created a dedicated WhatsApp Group for affiliated schools.
- Created a centralised school database and affiliation records.
- Improved our administrative and communication systems.
- Introduced online tournament registration.

These systems are intended to make it easier for schools to access information, register for events, maintain their affiliation details and stay connected with D&D.

If you are not yet on the whatsapp group or following the Facebook page, please click below to follow.



Looking Ahead — The D&D School League

One of the committee's key objectives is the introduction of a structured **Durban & Districts School Chess League**, creating a clear pathway of progression for school chess within the D&D community.

Through the introduction of **geographical zones** —— our affiliated schools will compete within their respective zones before qualifying for the **Durban & Districts Championships**. This structure is designed to provide a fair and meaningful progression system while giving learners regular competitive opportunities throughout the year.

Schools will be notified of their designated zones and the full league structure in due course.

We would also like to extend a special thank you to **Mrs Hoosen from Penzance Primary**, who has been a valuable source of advice and experience as we work through the practicalities of establishing and running a structured school chess league.

Schools that are not yet affiliated with Durban & Districts School Chess, but would like to participate in the **2027 league and championship pathway**, are invited to contact us at **ddschoolchess@gmail.com** for more information.

Registration cut-off: end August 2026

Thank You

Five months in, we are proud of the foundations that have been laid, but we recognise that this is only the beginning.

None of this progress would have been possible without our schools, teachers, coaches, volunteers, parents, sponsors and partners who continue to support school chess.

Thank you for being part of the D&D chess community. We look forward to continuing to build on this progress together.

Durban & Districts School Chess Association Committee